B2 Speaking

Describing and comparing photos

Talk for a minute about a picture: say what you see, speculate about it, and compare two photos.

Many speaking exams ask you to talk about photos for about a minute. Examiners want more than a list of objects: they want you to organise your description, guess what is happening, and compare.

Step	Useful language
Give the general picture	*This photo shows a family having a meal outdoors.*
Describe position	*In the foreground... In the background... On the left...*
Speculate	*They might be celebrating something. It looks as if it's a holiday. She seems to be...*
Compare	*Whereas the first photo is outdoors, the second is in an office. Both photos show...*
Give your view	*Personally, I'd prefer... because...*

Speculate with modals. You don't know the real story, so use *might, could, must* and *it looks like / as if*. *They must be tired; they've clearly been walking all day.*

Common mistakes. *In the photo I can see a man, a table, a dog...* is a list, not a description. And remember: *It looks like a party* (+ noun). Before a clause, *It looks as if they're having a party* is the safer choice in exams; *It looks like they're having a party* is common but informal.

Practice

1. Start a description of a photo of students in a library.
2. Speculate: A man is running to a bus stop with his bag open.

3. Make it more formal: It looks like they are very happy.
4. Compare: Photo A shows a busy city street; Photo B shows a quiet village.
5. Give your view with a reason: Which place would you prefer to live in?

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. This photo shows a group of students studying together in a library.
2. He might be late for work. / He must be in a hurry; it looks as if he's about to miss the bus.
3. It looks as if they are very happy. (or: They look very happy.)
4. Whereas Photo A shows a busy city street, Photo B shows a quiet village. Both are places where people live, but the pace of life seems very different.
5. For example: Personally, I'd prefer the village because it's calmer and closer to nature.